

Passages - Kokoro

Before he could destroy his wife's happiness, he destroyed himself.

When writing such letters, I was quite sincere. But after writing them, my mood would change.

On the train, I thought about my own inconsistency. The more I thought about it, the more fickle I seemed, and I became dissatisfied with myself. I then thought of Sensei and his wife, and the evening of my last dinner with them. I remembered Sensei saying, "Which of us will die first?" And I thought: "How can anyone answer such a question? And if Sensei knew the answer, what would he do? What would his wife do, if she knew? Probably, they would behave exactly as if they did not know. As I am sitting here now, helpless, though I know that my father is waiting to die..." I felt then the helplessness of man, and the vanity of his life.

I said nothing. No word of apology would have expressed how I felt. I hung my head in deep shame. Calmly, he had been waiting for his death, believing that he would die before my graduation. And I had been too stupid to realize how much it meant to my father to be alive when I graduated. I brought out my diploma from my bag, and carefully showed it to my father and mother: I had not packed it well, and it was badly creased.

And like most cowards I suffered because I could not decide.

I do believe that for love to grow there must first be the impact of novelty. Between two people who have always

known each other, that necessary stimulus can never be felt. Like the first whiff of burning incense, or like the taste of one's first cup of saké, there is in love that moment when all its power is felt.

The development or the destruction—of man's body and mind depends upon external stimuli. Unless one is very careful, and unless one sees to it that the intensity of the stimuli is gradually increased, one will find too late that the body, or the mind, has atrophied.

I merely laughed—though I knew in my heart that I was being despised

When the loftiness is merely in one's point of view, then one is hopelessly handicapped as a human being. No matter how full one's head might be with the image of greatness, one was useless, I found out, unless one was a worthy man first.

And so I stood still, not daring to take a step in any direction. I was like a sick person in bed, who falls into an uneasy sleep during the day. He opens his eyes as he comes out of his sleep, and sees clearly what is going on around him. Then for a moment or two, he is overcome by the feeling that in the midst of a world that moves he alone is still.

K, in his heavy way, confessed to me his agonized love for Ojosan.

I felt as if I had been turned into stone by a magician's wand. I could not even move my lips as K had done.

It would seem that my wife attributed my ennui to the fact that I had no material worries. This was understandable, since

not only did my mother-in-law have enough money to support herself and her daughter, but there was enough on my side to enable me to live without working. Besides, there is no doubt that I had learned to take my easy circumstances for granted. But material comfort was by no means responsible for my inaction. When I was cheated by my uncle I felt very strongly the unreliableness of men. I learned to judge others harshly, but not myself. I thought that in the midst of a corrupt world I had managed to remain virtuous. Because of K, however, my self-confidence was shattered. With a shock, I realized that I was no better than my uncle. I became as disgusted with myself as I had been with the rest of the world. Action of any kind became impossible for me.

How could I, then, rob her of her allotted life and force her to share my own destiny? The mere thought of doing such a cruel thing was terrible to me. Her fate had been pre-ordained no less than mine had been. To throw her into the fire that had been built for me would be an extremely unnatural and piteous thing to do.

"In all the world, I now have only you to turn to."